Managing AI Without Abdication of Human Authority

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AI can assist individuals in organizing data, recognizing patterns, and making quicker and simpler decisions. AI can produce extremely believable errors, wasted time, biased duplicate hits, and resource consumption. These two conflicting realities produce an ideal space for AI regulation that is more complicated than outlawing the technology or deregulating tech companies that produce it. In my view, it is still just a tool, whatever the intelligence of the output. People and their organizations should remain accountable in law, even if their products or services are making decisions about jobs, education, housing, healthcare or financial decisions. A balance of risk-appropriate regulation, rigorous testing, responsibility for our environment and day-to-day practices with good sense, would enable us to have the utility of AI without losing control of its outcome.

They are able to generate text, suggest what action to take, and possibly function with some minimal oversight. But no matter how technically autonomous it is, no matter how well it reads or makes suggestions, "acting" in the legal sense is not the same thing as being a legal person. I don't think future and current systems should have any right or responsibility that we would otherwise attach to a human simply because they would be capable of doing so. A person as a legal actor can be held liable for something; a person can suffer the consequences of their actions. But if a program discriminates against a loan candidate or offers recommendations for a procedure that's unsafe, blaming the program absolves the humans who built and use that code of any accountability.

This is a very serious counterargument. Harari (2026) goes so far as to say that this makes AI not a "run-of-the-mill passive tool" because "it might create new ideas, take actions that

humans didn't explicitly program into it." That is a legitimate concern: we cannot control and we cannot monitor ultra-intelligent systems very well. But greater independence provides an additional reason to assign responsibility to humans who released the technology. The more a company emits a powerful system, the more it should document a goal, test the system, practice how it would escalate, and pay for accidents due to negligence. Framing AI as a tool does not mean pretending it's a simple one.

The EU has another answer: the AI Act, which takes a different angle on legal personhood. More critical applications face greater controls under its risk-based approach; Article 14 stipulates that high-risk systems must provide “effective human oversight” (European Parliament & Council of the European Union, 2024). This is more feasible than trying to identify the consciousness of a chatbot. There are real risks and clear winners, so laws could say if someone with the right skills can check, question, or block an outcome. For instance, if an AI says a property's value seems right, that might help an appraiser or investor, but they'd still want to check the numbers themselves.

Algorithmic bias is an obvious short-term ethical issue because the training data for an AI system was created by humans in the past, and some records for access to a job, a loan, or a home may have been biased. If data is used without questioning, the resulting automated system can seem neutral while perpetuating these biases. That's why AI risk management should span the entire lifecycle of a product, from design and development to deployment and evaluation, according to the National Institute of Standards and Technology AI Risk Management Framework (Tabassi, 2023). Deviating from this approach may mean fairness is treated as a point-in-time test, while there is no doubt that data is not available to indicate that.

Regulation should be proportionate to the potential damage it could do. We wouldn't want to require a tool that manages personal notes to be subject to the same rules as an automated mortgage screening tool. For more important uses, organizations should keep track of how decisions are made, let people question mistakes, and double-check results with independent tests when needed. Make it human reviewed, a human reviewer should have relevant information at their fingertips, and be able to change a decision. Sure, those protections may cost extra and take more time, but for folks whose lives and opportunities are riding on the result, it’s worth it. But rules should still be flexible enough that small organisations aren’t excluded due to prohibitive costs to participate in innovative activity.

Environmental impacts also need to be considered. AI isn’t just floating out there in some invisible digital world—it depends on thousands of real data centers, power grids, cooling systems, and machines. The International Energy Agency (2025) reported that data centres used around 1.5% of the world’s electricity in 2024, and that this amount could more than double by 2030. That is an estimate of data centres, not AI. But the IEA identified AI as a key growth factor. Governments should require disclosure of water and energy consumption, support demand-shifted computing and cleaner electricity, and evaluate the local environmental impacts of any new largescale facilities. Businesses should also ask whether the work requires a resource-heavy approach when a smaller system would suffice.

There is a delicate ecosystem of priorities. AI, in turn, could fuel cleaner energy systems by aiding in forecasting, building management and grid operation (International Energy Agency, 2025). The new standard shouldn't be that development must cease because of its emissions. It should be to quantify its costs in an honest way and to accept a defined, fair effort to keep those costs low. Any community that will pay the price in increased water or electrical consumption

deserves full disclosure and a voice in its local planning. Any greenwash must be verified against actual operational impact.

The last problem is that convenience substitutes for thought. If your AI tool can generate an explanation or suggest a course of action on the spot, you might adopt it just because it "knows what it's talking about." The course says that if you let that become habitual, "your brain may learn to bypass logical reasoning altogether." I share that skepticism, but I don't think routinely using AI for that purpose is necessarily bad. Calculators didn't do away with the study of math, and an AI assistant shouldn't do away with evidence-based thinking; the difference is in how we use each.

I would set a simple rule: the more at stake, the more independent review required. I think it is fine to rely on AI to come up with a shopping list for dinner, or to create a summary of a lengthy document, so long as important assertions are sourced and verified. For decisions about one's health, or investments, contracts, jobs and legal rights, gather data sources, explore options and seek expert professional advice. For decisions in commercial property, for instance, using AI to list comparable property or compile lease terms, but not relying on it to analyze the lease, verify numbers or inspect a property, and not using it to decide whether to buy, is reasonable. A charming answer is not a reliable one.

Schools and offices can discourage complacency by teaching people how to query AI - rather than memorize the prompts. Students should be able to say not only what an answer is but why it is credible, where the information came from and what uncertainties there are. Companies should delegate serious decisions and arm their people with the skills to catch falsehoods. We

would thus retain an important human capability: to outvote a machine, even at the expense of extra time. AI can democratize knowledge, but it cannot arbitrate its importance.

AI can deliver real value, but those benefits are not contingent on making it a person or letting it take over human lives. I believe we should hold people and organisations accountable for how AI is designed and used, through risk-based regulation, bias testing, environmental accountability, and rights to human review enforceable by law-each of which can help avoid unnecessary harm while supporting positive innovation. And for the individual, AI must be a human supplement, not a human replacement. AI wins when it appears to be able to do every human decision, but when human citizens who are informed, responsible, and able-willing, even-are ultimately the ones to decide.

References

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